coordination and also my awareness of which direction the bat should come from to meet the ball.

My uncle and aunt's house was a thirty-minute walk from school. It meant I could get more rest in the morning and could come home for lunch around 1 p.m. and go back to play a practice game at my club by early afternoon. Sir would invariably schedule three practice games a week for me and would ensure that I batted at number four in each one of them. He could do that because it was his club. I would bat in my favourite position in all the matches I played and if I got out I'd have to change quickly and go out and field. This was a good incentive to keep batting and not get out at all, as I didn't enjoy fielding anything like as much as batting. After the match I'd resume my own training in the evening before calling it a day at 7.30.

On days when there was a school match, we'd try our best to stretch it to a second day. For example, if we were set to chase 300 we'd score 260–270 runs on the first day and keep the remaining runs for the next morning. This would allow us to miss school on the second day, and after quickly wrapping up the match in the first half an hour, the team would head off to the beach to play cricket. Playing beach cricket was always a lot of fun and we would all have a great time.

Both my parents would visit me at my uncle and aunt's almost every day after they finished work. For my mother in particular it was an arduous journey, since travelling there from her office in Santa Cruz in peak-hour traffic on public transport was a real challenge back then. The fact that both of them would happily put in the time after a full day's work, just so I would not feel neglected, was remarkable.

In the 1986–87 season I started to make runs consistently and also scored my first hundred. We were playing Don Bosco School at Shivaji Park and I was not out on 94 at the end of the first day. A few days before this match I had invited Sir to my house for dinner. Sir, however, said he would come only when I had scored my first hundred in school cricket. Feeling excited and anxious, I decided to sleep with my father that night and kept tossing and turning till late. My father tried to comfort me, saying I should go to sleep and that my body needed rest after batting all day. I couldn't and only managed to get a couple of hours' sleep before waking up very early the next morning.

Sensing my anxiety, my father took me to a Ganapati temple in Bandra to seek the blessings of Lord Ganesha and only then did I leave